

To Love or To Be Loved. That is the Question.

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Tips of the Day · 2 min read

The Buddhaddhamma teaches that we have unconscious desires, the anusaya, latent tendencies. The habits we have formed lie beneath our conscious life and rise only when some stimulus activates a given unskillful reaction. But like little devils, the anusaya are always there influencing the way we behave. Freud also was well aware of this and we have the 'Freudian slip' to tell us how embarrassed we can be by such unwelcome intervention. The whole area of love is fraught with such little devils. And we have to ask ourselves constantly: Am I thinking, saying and doing this as an expression of love for the other or as a means to get them to love me, appreciate me or both? According to psychoanalysis, as babies we are utterly identified with our mothers. As the necessary separation takes place so we can become individuals in our own right, we lose the safety and warmth of that union. So there is a longing to re-establish such a heavenly union for the rest of our lives. One reason why falling in love is so enthralling, is because it reminds us of that earlier union with our mothers. The Dhamma digs a little deeper to the sense of self and how it drives us to seek delight 'now here, now there'. But it sits on a bed of insecurity, highlighted only when the shadow of death is glimpsed. There is no greater reassurance in that dread than the embrace of another. False refuge, yet it does serve to allay the sickled ghost. In that need, we find ourselves unconsciously offering our love in order to be loved. Yet in doing so, we are developing all the neediness and selfishness that insecurity can develop. We become anxious about whether we are liked or not, good enough or not. We must butter up our self-esteem by doing good for the other, impressing the other. We find ourselves going over the top to help and find we are even becoming nuisances. Rejection for such 'generous offering' stings and we tend to blame the other for their ingratitude. 'I have done so much for you' Paradoxically, when all our intentions bend to love, to care for the other, sensitive to their needs, we find that self-esteem arises naturally. Such is the product of virtue. There is no need for appreciation or gratitude to be expressed. What practice can we set ourselves to move towards a pure loving? First, we must heighten our sense of awareness around our intentions now that we are forewarned. Second, we must be sure the intention is a fully conscious act so that the unwholesome intentions are not reinforced and so, unexercised, simply wither. And the reflection after any conversation or act and especially at the end of the day, gently pointing to errors and being joyful at successes that lead to a greater love and care.

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